says. The experience led her to establish a 100-acre permaculture farm, Polam, on the banks of the Manjeera reservoir in the same district in 2015. A similar train of thought led Malvikaa Solanki, a wilderness researcher at the Indian Institute of Science, to permaculture. "Over time, I realised that city life was unsustainable. I felt if I wanted to live a life honourably, I needed to live off the land," she says. In 2014, she bought a six-acre property (now known as Open Shell Farm) near the Bandipur Tiger Reserve in Karnataka.

Even celebrities have been bitten by the permaculture bug. S.S. Rajamouli, the director of blockbusters such as *Baahubali* and *RRR*, is transforming his 100-acre farm in Eduluru village in Telangana's Nalgonda district into a food forest. Again, it was a chance encounter with Dr Koppula that led to the transformation. Rajamouli was fascinated by his concepts of symbiotic relationships and harmonious coexistence with nature. The two are collaborating to create the auteur's permaculture farm, which will also now have a house, a natural structure built using mud bricks and lime plastering. The construction should be complete by year-end, and Rajamouli says he plans to spend his free time at his sustainable sanctuary once it's done.

Meanwhile, Koppula is now busy conducting a 13-day residential permaculture design course every month at his farm for up to 20 students. On the days when he isn't teaching, he is off to meet farmers from across Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. On the day of the interview, he had travelled 130 km to Wanaparthy in southern Telangana to assist a farmer in setting up a water harvesting structure. "We need to define how we want to live. Money is a part of the equation...health and happiness are equally important, and those stem from sharing," he says.

COMMUNITY SHARING

Permaculture offers a set of design principles to build sustainable ecosystems modelled on natural ones. Some of its elements—like water conservation (through contour bunding, swales and water harvesting structures), soil fertility (mulching and composting) and native tree plantations—are a given. But there are others, like stacking plants that thrive together. For instance, in the shade of a mango tree, elephant yam can flourish, along





"We invited him (Dr Koppula) to our farm and were fascinated with the permaculture ethos he shared with us...about living a meaningful life and being one with Nature"

–S.S. RAJAMOULI, *Film director*

WHAT IS PERMACULTURE?

- It is a model of agriculture that leverages complementary qualities of the land, plants, trees and animals to create a food forest that is self-sustaining and in harmony with nature

INVESTMENTS REQUIRED TO START A FOOD FOREST

- Capital investment for buying the land, constructing fences, building water sources (rainwater harvesting structure or borewell), and constructing residential structures
- Once up and running, operation costs are limited to labour, upkeep